

STUDY SHEET — PARASHAH SHOFTIM

Deuteronomy 16:18–21:9 · Haftarah: Isaiah 51:12–52:12 · Gospel: John 14:9–20 · The Frame

§0. Observation round (order-safeguarding)

This round fixes the production order: first observe, then the axes as an open question, then read off the center of gravity, and only then the thread. The directional test is the horizon, not the starting point.

0.1 Blind observation

The parashah opens with an imperative of institutions: ‘Judges and officials you shall appoint in all your gates’ (16:18), and immediately the loudest line of the whole: tzedek tzedek tirdof — ‘justice, justice you shall pursue’ (16:20). Then, block by block, the bearers of authority and their limits: the judge (no bribe, no partiality), the high court, the king (whom God chooses but who does not multiply horses/wives/gold and writes out the Torah), the priests (whose inheritance is the LORD), the ban on divination, the prophet like Moses with his test, the cities of refuge, the witness rule and proportionality, the laws of war, and the unsolved murder where the elders wash their hands. A recurring tension: authority that is commanded AND strictly bounded.

0.2 The four axes as an open question

Axis	What the text brings up	Weight
Source	The legitimacy of every office comes from God: the king whom He chooses (17:15), the prophet whom He raises (18:15), the priest whose inheritance is Himself (18:2). Illegitimate sources are rejected (divination 18:10–14, the false prophet 18:20).	Dominant.
Coherence	The whole parashah is one system of limits on power: the king does not lift his heart (17:20), the prophet is tested (18:22), two witnesses not one (19:15), proportionality (19:21), careful investigation (17:4).	Dominant — interlocks with Source.
Will	Present but bounded: pursue justice (16:20), establish institutions (16:18), wash the hands over innocent blood (21:6).	Supporting.
Trajectory	‘When you come into the land’ (17:14); the future king.	Thin.
Reactivity	Mild: ‘not like the nations’ who listen to soothsayers (18:9,14); the king who ‘does not return to Egypt’ (17:16).	Weak; not foregrounded.

0.3 Read-off center of gravity

Read off, not chosen: the parashah is about **righteous, bounded, legitimate authority** — who may judge, rule, speak, and by whose authority; and that every power stands under God and His Torah and remains accountable. The two bearing axes are **Source** (all authority comes from God) and **Coherence** (and is therefore testable and bounded). Backbone: tzedek tzedek tirdof (16:20) and the king-under-the-Torah (17:18–20).

0.4 Framing test

Did this come from the observation? Yes — the density is overwhelming (judges, court, king, priests, prophet, witnesses, cities of refuge, war, unsolved murder); it is almost the whole parashah.

Two pitfalls, named honestly. One: I could bend this back toward the directional rung (the false prophet and ‘you shall be blameless’ are, after all, about received versus grasped authority) — but that would flatten the core; the text does not press on the weighing but on the structure: how authority is instituted AND bounded. Two, more important: last week (Re’eh) I landed on the Source–Will relation; I must not impose that template now. Tested: the text stages the Source–Coherence coupling itself — 17:18–20 binds the source (God chooses the king) to the limit (he writes out the Torah), and 18:15–22 binds the prophet’s legitimacy to the test (does it come true?). It is observation, not import.

Outcome: it does not land on the directional rung, nor on last week’s Source–Will — it lands on **Source–Coherence**. That the text brought me elsewhere is the proof that the protocol observes rather than frames.

§1. The thread

Pursuing justice — authority that is given, and therefore bounded. All power in Shoftim is derived (the king, the prophet, the priest receive their place from God), and precisely therefore none is absolute: each office stands under the Torah and remains testable and accountable. The king who does not lift his heart and the prophet who is tested are the hinges.

§2. Peshat per block

2.1 Judges and justice (16:18–17:7)

- 16:18–20 — judges in the gates; no bribe or partiality; tzedek tzedek tirdof.
- 17:2–7 — idolatry is investigated carefully and requires two or three witnesses.

2.2 The high court (17:8–13)

- Too-difficult cases go to the place the LORD chooses, to the priests and the judge; their ruling is binding.

2.3 The king (17:14–20)

- God chooses him, from among your brothers; he does not multiply horses (no return to Egypt), wives, or gold.
- 17:18–20 — he writes out this Torah with his own hand and reads it for life, *‘that his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers’*. The hinge of the whole parashah: authority under the Word.

2.4 Priests and Levites (18:1–8)

- They have no inheritance; the LORD Himself is their inheritance. Their support lies in God, not in possessions.

2.5 No divination; blamelessness (18:9–14)

- Do not do as the nations (divination, sorcery, consulting the dead); *‘you shall be blameless (tamim) before the LORD your God’* (18:13).
- Weighing frame (application, not peshat-compulsion): the distinction lies not in the act but in the directedness — at God, or at the self. Embodied and creative gifts (writing that heals, music, movement, breath) are good in themselves; it goes wrong where the self becomes the center. God is the riverbed that carries; He made the body to serve Him.

2.6 The prophet like Moses (18:15–22)

- God raises a prophet like Moses to be heeded (18:15). The test: *'if the word does not come to pass, the LORD has not spoken it'* (18:22). Legitimate AND testable.

2.7 Cities of refuge, boundary stone, witnesses (19)

- Cities of refuge for unintentional manslaughter; do not move a boundary stone (19:14); one witness is not enough (19:15); the false witness receives what he intended for the other; proportionality (19:21).

2.8 Laws of war (20)

- The priest encourages; exemptions (new house, vineyard, betrothed, the fearful); first an offer of peace; and the spare-the-fruit-tree command (20:19–20).
- The exemptions and the spared fruit tree protect life and continuity, even in war — stewardship: the landscape is not the enemy. Cf. the land on loan (Lev. 25:23) and the vineyard line Eden → Isa. 5 → John 15.

2.9 The unsolved murder (21:1–9)

- The elders of the nearest town wash their hands: *'our hands have not shed this blood'* (21:7), and make atonement for innocent blood.

2.10 Haftarah — Isaiah 51:12–52:12

- Third comfort word: 'I, I am He who comforts you' (51:12); the watchmen on the walls; *'your God reigns'* (52:7); awake, awake; and the exodus language (52:11–12). All human offices are grounded in God's own kingship.

2.11 Gospel — John 14:9–20

- 14:9 'whoever has seen Me has seen the Father'; 14:10 *'the words I speak to you I do not speak from Myself; the Father who dwells in Me does the works'*; 14:16–17 the promise of the Comforter; 14:18 'I will not leave you as orphans'. Authority that is perfectly derived — and Yeshua as the prophet like Moses (18:15).

§3. The two bearing axes and their relation

3.1 Source — all authority is derived

The king, the prophet, the priest: none derives his place from himself. God chooses, raises, appoints. And the illegitimate sources (divination, the presumptuous prophet, other gods) are rejected precisely as source. Legitimacy is received, not arrogated.

3.2 Coherence — and therefore bounded

Because the authority is derived, it is not absolute. The king does not lift his heart and stands under the Torah; the prophet is tested by the outcome; judgment is bounded by witnesses, investigation, and proportionality. Power remains accountable — correctable.

3.3 The relation — three hinges

- 17:18–20 — God chooses the king (Source) AND binds him to writing out and reading the Torah (Coherence). Source and limit in one law.
- 18:15–22 — God raises the prophet (Source) AND sets the test: does the word come true? (Coherence).
- 16:19–20 + 19:15–21 — pursue justice (16:20) through bounded procedure: witnesses, investigation, proportionality.

Honest limit: this two-axis reading, too, can tempt to a too-neat synthesis. The safeguard is that 17:18–20 and 18:15–22 are structural hinges in the text itself, not brought by the reader.

§4. Deepening: the limit as service to the source

The four paradigm cases each show the same figure: authority that is carried by the limit it accepts. The king who writes out the Torah becomes not less king but more — he rules as a brother among brothers. The prophet who lets himself be tested is not disempowered but calibrated. The judge who requires two witnesses and judges proportionally becomes not weaker but trustworthy. Even in war a limit remains (the fruit tree, 20:19), and even at an unsolved murder responsibility is not waved away but carried (21:6–7). The limit here is no restriction of the authority; it is the form in which derived authority becomes trustworthy.

§5. The directional test as horizon

Beneath all this lies the one question — received or grasped — but this week that is the ground, not the theme. Illegitimate, self-arrogated authority (the presumptuous prophet 18:20, the king whose heart lifts itself 17:20, the false witness 19:18) is the grasped form; received, accountable, testable authority the received form. This time the text pressed hardest on the Source–Coherence relation; the direction is the floor beneath it. In the gospel that horizon becomes visible: *‘I do not speak from Myself’* (John 14:10) — the perfectly received authority.

§6. Status table

Status	Item	Note
● Bearing	Tzedek tzedek tirdof (16:20)	‘Justice, justice you shall pursue’ — the backbone: justice as a goal to be pursued, not a possession.
● Bearing	The king under the Torah (17:18–20)	God chooses the king AND binds him: he writes out the Torah and reads for life, ‘that his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers’. Source and limit in one law.
● Bearing	The prophet test (18:21–22)	‘If the word does not come to pass, the LORD has not spoken it.’ Authority legitimate AND testable.
● Bearing	Two or three witnesses (17:6; 19:15)	No conviction on one mouth; the procedure bounds the judgment.
● Bearing	Careful investigation (17:4; 19:18)	‘You shall inquire diligently’ — the truth is weighed before the sanction.
● Bearing	Proportionality (19:21)	‘Eye for eye’ as a bounding of retribution (not more), no incitement to revenge.
● Bearing	Priests: the LORD is their inheritance (18:1–2)	Their support lies not in possession or power but in God Himself.
● Bearing	‘Your God reigns’ (Isa. 52:7)	Haftarah: all human offices are grounded in God’s own kingship.
● Bearing	‘I do not speak from Myself’ (John 14:10)	The authority of the Son is perfectly derived: the Father in Him does the works. Direct embodiment of Source–Coherence.
● Suggestive	Tamim / ‘you shall be blameless’ (18:13)	Wholeness/undividedness over against divination; suggestive motif, after the peshat.

Status	Item	Note
● Suggestive	Sparing the fruit tree (20:19)	'Is the tree of the field a man?' — a limit even in war; homiletically usable as an image of bounded power.
● Suggestive	Washing the hands (21:6–7)	'Our hands have not shed this blood' — collective responsibility; suggestive toward atonement.
● Suggestive	Cities of refuge (19:1–13)	The refuge motif; outside the core of the center of gravity, mark as background.
● Suggestive	The vineyard: Eden → Isa. 5 → John 15	The line from God's garden (Gen. 2, 'work and keep') via Israel as vineyard (Isa. 5:7, where God sought 'justice and righteousness' — tzedek, cf. 16:20) to Yeshua, the true Vine (John 15). Carries the life motif of the parashah through.
● Suggestive	The land on loan (Lev. 25:23)	'The land is Mine; you are strangers and sojourners' — the land received, not owned; homiletically under the received-ground, outside the read pericope.
● Suggestive	Laws of war protect life (20:5–7, 19)	The exemptions (new house, vineyard, betrothal) and the spared fruit tree show a God of life and stewardship, even in war; suggestive-homiletical motif.
● Suggestive	Directedness as criterion (18:9–14)	The distinction is not the act itself but the directedness: at God, or at the self. Connects to tamim (18:13) and the received–grasped axis; application, not peshat-compulsion.
● Watch	'Eye for eye' not as revenge	The formula bounds precisely; do not present it as incitement to retribution.
● Watch	'Not like the nations' (18:9)	Aimed at divination as source, not a general condemnation of peoples.
● Watch	The king law not absolutely anti-monarchical	God permits the king (17:15) and bounds him; the text does not abolish the office.
● Watch	John 14:9–20 not apart from Israel	The Comforter promise and 'I will not leave you as orphans' (14:18) stand within the covenant, not as its replacement.
● Confession	The prophet like Moses → Yeshua (18:15)	That the announced prophet finds his fulfillment in Yeshua (cf. Acts 3:22) is confessional application, not an exegetically compelling datum.
● Confession	'Whoever has seen Me' (John 14:9)	The Son shows the invisible Source; read confessionally as the making-visible of the authority behind all offices.
● Confession	Authority 'not from Himself' (John 14:10)	Christological fulfillment of the Source–Coherence figure: perfectly derived, perfectly obedient authority.

§7. Podcast translation

Core in one sentence: in Shoftim all power — judge, king, prophet, priest — is given by God, and precisely therefore bounded; authority that cannot test itself is not from Him.

Image: the king who copies out the Torah with his own hand — the most powerful man in the land, with the Word on his lap, that his heart may not be lifted up.

Question to carry: which authority in my life — including my own — still lets itself be tested, and which no longer?

§8. Source accounting

- BHS, Deut. 16:18–21:9 — checkpoints: tzedek tzedek tirdof (16:20), the king law (17:18–20), the prophet test (18:22), tamim (18:13).
- BHS, Isa. 52:7 ('your God reigns') — checkpoint for the haftarah core.
- NA28, John 14:9–10 ('whoever has seen Me'; 'I do not speak from Myself') — checkpoint for the gospel, marked as confessional.
- Isa. 5:7 ('justice and righteousness' in God's vineyard), Lev. 25:23, Micah 4:4, and John 15:1 — checkpoints for the vineyard/life motif, marked confessional/suggestive.
- The placement of John 14:9–20 as gospel reading and the delimitation Isa. 51:12–52:12 (third comfort sabbath): liturgical/redactional given, marked as such.